

WI.5 Forms & Documents Index

Every document you will meet, who produces it, and where it goes — plus what needs no permit at all.

Before you use this document

This is a process reference, not legal advice. Wisconsin writes one Uniform Dwelling Code that binds every new one- and two-family dwelling in the state, and then splits the *enforcement* of it three ways — a municipality that inspects with its own staff, a municipality that contracts the work out, and a town that has never taken it up, where the state's own certified agency does it instead. Your septic permit comes from the county no matter which of the three you are in. Confirm every item with the office that will actually handle your parcel before you rely on it. Form numbers and revision dates change. Where this document names a form number it was read directly; where it names only a title, the number could not be verified and you should ask the issuing office for the current form.

THE DOCUMENTS, IN THE ORDER YOU WILL MEET THEM

What each document is, who makes it, and where it goes

Document	Produced by	Filed with	Notes
Soil and Site Evaluation Report	A state-certified soil tester	The county	Every page signed with the tester's identification number and the date
POWTS plans and specifications	A registered POWTS designer, architect, engineer or designer of plumbing systems — or the master plumber who will install it	The county, or the department in the counties without plan-review delegation	Includes the management plan that sets your servicing intervals
Sanitary Permit Application	You, as the property owner — but it must name your master plumber	The county	The permit runs to you , not the installer. Valid 2 years, renewable, and transferable with the land
Zoning / land use permit application	You	County zoning in unincorporated towns; otherwise the municipality	Add shoreland and floodplain review if the parcel is near water

What each document is, who makes it, and where it goes

Document	Produced by	Filed with	Notes
Well notification	You, or the driller on your behalf	Department of Natural Resources	Before construction begins. The driller must verify the notification number exists before spudding in
Wisconsin Uniform Building Permit Application form SBD-5823	You	Your municipality, county, the department, or your registered UDC inspection agency	Carries the erosion control request on the same form, and a checkbox for one acre or more of disturbance
Cautionary Statement to Owners Obtaining Building Permits	You sign it	The permit issuer	Mandatory for every owner applicant — see WI.1
Driveway / access permit application	You	The authority that maintains the road	Town board, county highway department, or the Department of Transportation
Notice of Intent, construction site stormwater	You, as landowner	Department of Natural Resources	Only at one acre or more; 14 working days ahead, with the plan already complete
Well Construction Report	The driller	The department and you , within 30 days, electronically	Keep your copy — it is the permanent record of casing, static level, yield and geology
Water sample results — total coliform and nitrate	The driller collects; a laboratory reports	As directed	Required after new well construction by rule, not merely by a lender
POWTS maintenance and servicing reports	Your servicing provider performs; you report	The county, within 30 days of the event	The reporting duty sits on the owner for the life of the system

The Wisconsin uniform building permit and its application are reproduced in the code itself — “See ch. SPS 325 Appendix A for a copy of the Wisconsin uniform building permit and application” (Note to s. SPS 320.09). The sanitary permit application and the soil evaluation report are prescribed by the department but are named here by title only: the rule says the application “shall be made in a format prescribed by the department” (s. SPS 383.21(2)(a)) without giving a number, and no department form number could be verified for either in this pass. Ask your county for the current forms.

WHAT NEEDS NO UDC PERMIT AT ALL

Section SPS 320.05 lists twelve exemptions from the code. Several are genuinely useful to an owner-builder, and two are traps.

Exemptions from the Uniform Dwelling Code — s. SPS 320.05

Exemption	What it actually covers
Detached garages and accessory buildings	Outside the code, <i>“with the exception of s. SPS 321.08(1)”</i> — the dwelling-separation rule still applies. Your municipality may still require a permit for it by ordinance under s. SPS 320.02(2)(c)
Detached decks	Outside the code <i>“provided the deck does not serve an exit from the dwelling”</i> . A deck at your back door is not detached in the sense that matters
Farm buildings	Outside the code where <i>“used exclusively for farm operations and not for human habitation”</i> . Both halves must be true
Repairs and maintenance	Outside the code, including repair of electrical, plumbing, heating, ventilating and air conditioning systems already installed
Existing dwellings	The code does not reach a dwelling begun before its effective date, or additions and alterations to one — unless your municipality has adopted the code for those by ordinance
Dwellings on tribal trust land	Outside the code where the land is <i>“held in trust by the United States”</i>
Camping units	Governed by ch. SPS 327 instead
Religious waiver dwellings	Where a waiver has been accepted under Wis. Stat. s. 101.648. Neither a municipality nor the department <i>“may charge a person a fee to apply for or to receive a waiver”</i>
Primitive rural hunting cabins	Grandfathered only — the structure must trace to one built before 31 December 1997. You cannot build a new one. See WI.1

Two exemptions that are not exemptions

Calling it a cabin changes nothing. The scope note to s. SPS 320.02(1)(a) says the code reaches *“site-built dwellings, manufactured buildings used as dwellings, modular homes and dwellings that may be designated as **cabins**, **seasonal homes**, **temporary residences**, etc.”* A seasonal place on a lake is a dwelling and needs a permit.

The park-model trap. A titled recreational vehicle is outside the code — but only while it stays a vehicle. The note to s. SPS 320.05(9) is explicit: at the installation site *“the chassis and axles shall remain on the unit, with the towbar (hitch) and wheels left at the site. **Otherwise the unit, including a park model, is subject to the UDC.**”* Take the axles off and you have converted a vehicle into a dwelling that has to meet the code.

And a third worth knowing: three or more dwelling units leaves the UDC entirely and lands in the commercial building code, chs. SPS 361 to 366 — a different code, a different plan review and, for an owner-builder, a very different project.

THE CREDENTIALS — WHAT TO ASK A SUB TO SHOW YOU

You signed a statement at permit application saying you understand what happens if you hire an uninsured contractor. This is the table that makes that statement actionable. Verify each credential yourself through the department's public license search rather than accepting a card at face value.

Who holds what, and what it proves

Credential	Held by	What it actually proves
Dwelling Contractor Certification	Held by the <i>business</i> , through its owner, a partner, or the chairman or chief executive	Proves financial responsibility: a bond of at least \$5,000 or general liability cover of at least \$250,000 per occurrence, plus worker's compensation and unemployment compliance. Valid one year
Dwelling Contractor — Restricted	Same, but bonded under \$25,000	The holder agrees “ <i>not to perform any work on a dwelling for which the estimated cost of completion is greater than the amount of the bond</i> ”. Check the bond amount against your job
Dwelling Contractor Qualifier	Held by an <i>individual</i>	Proves education: at least 12 hours in an approved dwelling construction course covering construction laws, construction codes and business practices, with tests
Master Plumber / Master Plumber-Restricted Service	Individual license	Required for your POWTS, and named on your building permit for the plumbing installation. Licenses issue only to individuals and are not transferable
Certified Soil Tester	Individual certification	Required before anyone may construct soil bore holes or conduct the tests behind your sanitary permit
Electrician credentials	Master, journeyman, or registered — with residential-only variants	A residential master or journeyman electrician is limited to “ <i>wiring associated with dwellings, dwelling units and detached accessory buildings ... such as garages, carports, gazebos, and swimming pools</i> ” — which is exactly your job, so a residential credential is not a lesser one here
Registered HVAC Contractor	Registration, not a license	Mandatory for anyone in the business of HVAC work, but it involves no examination. The exam-based certification is voluntary. For refrigerant work, ask for the federal EPA section 608 card instead

Wis. Stat. ss. 101.654(2)(a), (2m), (3)(b), 101.178(2), (3)(a), 145.06(2), 145.045(1); Wis. Admin. Code ss. SPS 305.31, 305.315, 305.40(2)(a), 305.70(1). Remember that your own exemption means none of this financial backing stands behind the parts you build yourself — carry your own liability cover.

WHAT YOU KEEP AFTER THE FINAL INSPECTION

Three obligations outlive the build, and the first one surprises people because it lands on the owner rather than on a contractor.

Septic reporting is yours. *“The owner of a POWTS or the owner's agent shall report to the governmental unit or designated agent at the completion of each inspection, evaluation, maintenance, or servicing event specified in the approved management plan”, and “the owner of a POWTS is responsible for fulfillment of the reporting requirements under this section” (s. SPS 383.55(1)(a), (c)).* Reports go in within **30 calendar days** of the event and must carry the system's identifying number, its location, the date, and the license, certification or registration number of whoever did the work (s. SPS 383.55(2), (3)). A system *“not maintained in accordance with the approved management plan ... shall be considered a human health hazard”* (s. SPS 383.53(2)).

The septic interval is not a calendar

The familiar “pump it every three years” is not what Wisconsin's rule says for a new system. Servicing of an anaerobic treatment tank *“shall occur at least when the combined sludge and scum volume equals **1/3 of the tank volume**”* (s. SPS 383.54(3)(b)) — a measurement, not a date. The three-year figure is a **visual inspection** duty, and it applies to systems that existed before 1 July 2000 (s. SPS 383.54(4)(d)1.). For your new system, the intervals are whatever your approved management plan says, so read it and put those dates in your calendar.

Keep the well construction report — it is the only permanent record of what the driller found, and a buyer, a lender or a pump installer will want it years from now. And **keep this kit with the permit**: the sources are printed on every page so that a future owner, inspector or appraiser can check any claim in it against the code as it stood when you built.

Sources — every Wisconsin claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
The uniform permit and application are printed in the code	Note to s. SPS 320.09; ch. SPS 325 Appendix A
The sanitary permit application format is prescribed but unnumbered in the rule	s. SPS 383.21(2)(a)
The twelve exemptions from the code	s. SPS 320.05(1) to (12)
Cabins, seasonal homes and temporary residences are inside the code	Note to s. SPS 320.02(1)(a)
The park-model chassis and axle rule	Note to s. SPS 320.05(9)

Sources — every Wisconsin claim in this document (verified September 2026)

What this document states	Authority
Three or more units go to the commercial code	s. SPS 320.05(2); chs. SPS 361 to 366
A municipality may require permits for work outside the code	s. SPS 320.02(2)(c)
The religious waiver and its no-fee rule	Wis. Stat. s. 101.648(8)
Bond of \$5,000 or liability cover of \$250,000	Wis. Stat. s. 101.654(2)(a)
The restricted certification and its bond ceiling	Wis. Stat. s. 101.654(2m)
What a residential electrician credential covers	s. SPS 305.40(2)(a)
Plumbing licenses issue only to individuals	Wis. Stat. s. 145.06(2)
POWTS reporting sits on the owner; 30 calendar days	s. SPS 383.55(1)(a), (c), (2), (3)
Servicing at one third sludge and scum volume	s. SPS 383.54(3)(b)
The 3-year visual inspection applies to pre-2000 systems	s. SPS 383.54(4)(d)1.

Everything cited in this kit is free to read at **docs.legis.wisconsin.gov**, and the site takes a citation directly as a URL. For a statute — a **Wis. Stat.** section such as 101.65 — open **docs.legis.wisconsin.gov/statutes/statutes/101** and find the section in the chapter. For a rule — a **Wis. Admin. Code** chapter such as SPS 321 or NR 812 — open **docs.legis.wisconsin.gov/code/admin_code** and pick the agency: **SPS** is Safety and Professional Services, which writes the Uniform Dwelling Code and the septic code, and **NR** is Natural Resources, which writes the well code and shoreland zoning. **One habit worth keeping when you check a number:** every chapter page prints its register date at the foot, in the form “Register month year No. nnn”. That date, not the year in the chapter title, tells you how current the text on your screen is. All text here was read at that source, September 2026.